SELECTED WORKS FROM A
PRIVATE NIGERIAN COLLECTION

Kelani Abass

THE EARLY PATRONAGE COLLECTION

Six paintings | 2006-2007

Architecture, performance
and the everyday

Ozuwo Enifome Collection
Nigeria | October 2026



An Early Patronage Collection

Six paintings from the collection of Ozuwo Enifome, Nigeria

A figure passes between sunlit walls. Musicians fill the picture with the sweep of a yellow garment. Chickens cross an enclosed yard, while rooftops and trees mark the edges of a wider settlement. These six early paintings bring together distinct encounters with inhabited places: their light, their surfaces and the people who give them scale.

Produced in 2006 and 2007, the works span the period around Kelani Abass’s graduation from Yaba College of Technology. The four smaller paintings concentrate on architectural spaces and performance. Two larger compositions extend the view towards the skyline and the tree-lined road, while the reported fabric application in *The Quiet Road* adds a material dimension to the painted ground.

The collection was formed through Ozuwo Enifome’s direct patronage relationship with the artist, beginning in 2006. Presented together, the paintings provide a focused opportunity to examine Abass’s handling of oil paint, spatial construction and everyday subject matter during this early period. They precede the photographic and archival works through which his practice has subsequently reached international museum audiences.

Reading the catalogue. All dimensions are height × width, unframed, in inches and centimetres. Descriptive titles are provisional. Object information and provenance are supplied by the collector; full documentation notes appear on page 12.

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Kelani Abass

Nigerian artist | Born 1979 | Lives and works in Lagos

Painting, Photography and the Work of Memory

Kelani Abass works across painting, photography, print and assemblage, examining how images and objects preserve personal experience within a larger social history. He studied painting at Yaba College of Technology, Lagos, graduating with distinction in 2007. His early professional recognition includes the Yusuf Grillo Award for best painting student in 2007 and first prize in painting at the Caterina de Medici/3rd Black Heritage Prize in 2010. [1, 3]

The materials of his family's printing business have become central to his practice. Photographs, letterpress cases, printed documents and painted passages are brought into compositions that hold several moments together. Their surfaces suggest that memory is assembled through acts of selection, repetition and re-reading. His projects *Àsìkò* (2013) and *If I Could Save Time* (2016), at the Centre for Contemporary Art, Lagos, developed this engagement with family history, technological change and the passage of time. [2-4]

Abass was an artist in residence at Headlands Center for the Arts, California, in 2018. International presentations include *New Photography 2023* at MoMA, New York; *Re-Mixing African Photography* at the Art Gallery of Ontario; and *A World in Common* at Tate Modern, London, and subsequently C/O Berlin. More recent presentations include the collection display accompanying *Safiotra* at Fondation H, Madagascar, and the 2026 two-person exhibition *Faire face* at Galerie Dagoma-Harty, Paris. [6-12, 14]

His work is represented in the collections of The Museum of Modern Art, New York, and the Art Gallery of Ontario, Toronto. These holdings include works from his later photographic and mixed-media practice. [7, 15]

Selected Solo Exhibitions

2009-2021 | Reverse chronological order

2021 **Unfolding Layers of Time**

Curated solo project, ART X Lagos, The Federal Palace, Lagos, Nigeria. 4-7 November. [5]

2016 **If I Could Save Time**

Centre for Contemporary Art, Lagos, Nigeria. [4]

2016 **Aso Igba**

Art Clip Africa, Lagos, Nigeria. [1]

2013 **Àsìkò: Evoking Personal Narratives and Collective History**

Centre for Contemporary Art, Lagos, Nigeria. Curated by Bisi Silva; co-curated by Jude Anogwih. [3]

2011 **Man and Machine**

Omenka Gallery, Lagos, Nigeria. [1, 3]

2009 **Paradigm Shift**

Mydrim Gallery, Lagos, Nigeria. [1, 3]

Selected record. Two-person and group exhibitions, including recent presentations through 2026, follow on page 5.

Selected Group Exhibitions

2023-2026 | Two-person and group presentations | Reverse chronological order by opening year

2026 *Faire face*

Two-person exhibition with M’barek Bouhchichi. Galerie Dagoma-Harty, Paris, France. 28 May-31 July. [10]

2025-2026 *Safiotra [Hybridités/Hybridities]*

Participation in the Fondation H collection selection accompanying Yinka Shonibare’s exhibition. Fondation H, Antananarivo, Madagascar. 11 April 2025-21 March 2026. [11]

2025 *Time Heals, Just Not Quick Enough…*

Efie Gallery, Dubai, United Arab Emirates. Curated by Ose Ekore. 1 June-30 July. [13]

2025 *A World in Common: Contemporary African Photography*

C/O Berlin, Berlin, Germany. 1 February-8 May. [12]

2023-2024 *Re-Mixing African Photography*

With Mallory Lowe Mpoka and Abraham Oghobase. Art Gallery of Ontario, Toronto, Canada. 8 July 2023-7 January 2024. [7]

2023-2024 *A World in Common: Contemporary African Photography*

Tate Modern, London, United Kingdom. 6 July 2023-14 January 2024. [2, 9]

2023 *New Photography 2023*

The Museum of Modern Art, New York, United States. 28 May-16 September. [6]

2023 *Indigo Waves and Other Stories: Re-Navigating the Afrasian Sea and Notions of Diaspora*

Gropius Bau, Berlin, Germany. [8]



Village Passage

Provisional descriptive title

Kelani Abass | 2006
Oil on canvas
12 × 16 in | 30.48 × 40.64 cm
Height × width

A solitary figure gives scale to this narrow passage between closely spaced buildings. Pale light runs through the centre of the scene, held between the orange warmth of the wall at left and a deeply shadowed roofline above. The eye follows this illuminated route towards the more distant houses.

In the foreground, broken strokes of green, ochre and grey keep the ground uneven and tactile. The contrast between these open marks and the enclosing architecture gives the scene its particular intimacy: a small, ordinary route becomes a study of how light changes the experience of a place.

PROVENANCE

Artist; acquired directly by Ozuwo Enifome through a patronage arrangement; private collection, Nigeria.



The Historic Gateway

Provisional descriptive title

Kelani Abass | 2006
Oil on canvas
16 × 12 in | 40.64 × 30.48 cm
Height × width

The pointed opening of a tall gateway frames a second architectural view beyond, creating a passage within a passage. Its reddish mass rises against a pale sky, while the converging ground draws attention towards the entrance. Small figures and a motorcyclist interrupt the monument’s stillness.

The composition depends on differences of scale. Architecture occupies most of the canvas, yet the people moving around its base establish the setting as an active public space. The site is not identified here; the descriptive title refers to the gateway’s appearance.

PROVENANCE

Artist; acquired directly by Ozuwo Enifome through a patronage arrangement; private collection, Nigeria.



Traditional Musicians

Provisional descriptive title

Kelani Abass | 2006
Oil on canvas
16 × 12 in | 40.64 × 30.48 cm
Height × width

A musician in a vivid yellow garment commands the foreground, his red headwear set against the darker tones around his face. Behind him, a second performer holds a drum. Their overlapping positions draw the figures together while maintaining the prominence of the leading performer.

Long strokes carry the yellow fabric down through the composition, giving the garment a movement of its own. This broad handling contrasts with the concentrated dark marks of the faces and instruments. Performance is conveyed through bodily presence, colour and the visual rhythm of the brushwork.

PROVENANCE

Artist; acquired directly by Ozuwo Enifome through a patronage arrangement; private collection, Nigeria.



Courtyard with Chickens

Provisional descriptive title

Kelani Abass | 2006
Oil on canvas
12 × 16 in | 30.48 × 40.64 cm
Height × width

A sunlit patch of ground opens between weathered buildings, with chickens providing small points of movement across the yard. Pink and mauve walls meet cooler passages of blue and grey, while green touches at the edges interrupt the earthen palette.

The courtyard is organised through adjoining planes rather than fine architectural detail. Shadows break across the foreground, and the brighter ground leads the eye inward. These shifts give the enclosed space depth without losing the directness of the painted surface. The birds anchor the scene in the incidental activity of a shared domestic environment.

PROVENANCE

Artist; acquired directly by Ozuwo Enifome through a patronage arrangement; private collection, Nigeria.



Rooftops and Settlement

Provisional descriptive title

Kelani Abass | 2007
Oil on canvas
26 × 36 in | 66.04 × 91.44 cm
Height × width

The viewpoint looks across a close pattern of roofs towards an open horizon. Muted reds and dark, slanting roof planes crowd the foreground, while softer greens and greys carry the settlement into the distance. Above, a broad sky introduces a slower, more diffuse movement.

The composition balances density below with openness above. Its interest lies in the meeting of built and atmospheric space: the roofs are distinct but interlocking, while the distant landscape dissolves into light. The larger format allows the painting to gather several structures into a single, sustained view.

PROVENANCE

Artist; acquired directly by Ozuwo Enifome through a patronage arrangement; private collection, Nigeria.



The Quiet Road

Provisional descriptive title

Kelani Abass | 2007
Oil and fabric collage on stretched canvas
42 × 36 in | 106.68 × 91.44 cm
Height × width

A road curves into a settlement beneath a broad canopy of trees. Dark foliage gathers above the warm ground, with patches of sky opening between the branches. Buildings and a small distant figure establish scale and draw attention towards the bend in the road.

The collector describes coarse khaki cloth applied sparingly to the lower foreground before priming and overpainting in oil. This treatment gives the ground a material texture alongside its painted colour. The work combines the shade of the canopy, the openness of the road and the physical surface of the foreground within one continuous view.

PROVENANCE

Artist; acquired directly by Ozuwo Enifome through a patronage arrangement; private collection, Nigeria.

Provenance and Documentation

Ozuwo Enifome Collection | Nigeria

A direct patronage relationship

Ozuwo Enifome met Kelani Abass in 2006 and became his patron during the artist's student years. According to the collector, all six paintings were acquired directly from Abass through that arrangement and have remained in his private collection in Nigeria. Four works were produced in 2006 and two in 2007. These are production dates; individual acquisition dates have not yet been specified. Formal acquisition records are limited.

Object records

Attribution and titles. Identification of the six works as paintings by Kelani Abass rests on the collector's account of direct acquisition. Titles are provisional catalogue descriptions, not confirmed artist titles.

Measurements. All dimensions are height × width, unframed. Measurements and production dates are collector-supplied; centimetre figures are conversions of the reported inch measurements.

Materials. KA-01 to KA-05 are recorded as oil on canvas. KA-06 is recorded as oil and fabric collage on stretched canvas, following the collector's latest description. Materials and supports have not been independently examined.

Supporting evidence

Artist confirmation. Signed artist identification, certificates and dated transfer records have not been supplied for this edition. The provenance narrative is a collector statement, not an authentication certificate.

Condition and photographs. No professional condition reports or conservation history have been supplied. Reproductions derive from the collector's existing photographs and are not a substitute for physical examination.

Exhibitions and interpretation. The career exhibitions listed on pages 4-5 are not exhibition histories for these six paintings. No individual exhibition or publication history is established here. Artwork notes are editorial readings of the supplied images.

Sources

Artist biography and selected exhibitions | Accessed 20 October 2026

1. SMO Contemporary Art

Kelani Abass: biography

2. Rele Gallery

Kelani Abass: biography

3. Centre for Contemporary Art, Lagos

Àsìkò: exhibition archive

4. Centre for Contemporary Art, Lagos

If I Could Save Time: 2016 exhibition archive

5. ART X Lagos

Unfolding Layers of Time; 2021 fair programme

6. The Museum of Modern Art

New Photography 2023: exhibition record

7. Art Gallery of Ontario

Re-Mixing African Photography: exhibition and collection record

8. Gropius Bau / Berliner Festspiele

Indigo Waves and Other Stories: exhibition record

9. Tate Modern

A World in Common: 2023-2024 exhibition record

10. Galerie Dagoma-Harty

Faire face: exhibition text and gallery exhibition archive

11. Fondation H

Safiotra: exhibition and accompanying collection selection

12. C/O Berlin

A World in Common: 2025 exhibition record

13. Efie Gallery

Time Heals, Just Not Quick Enough…: exhibition record

14. Headlands Center for the Arts

Kelani Abass: 2018 artist residency and statement

15. The Museum of Modern Art

Casing History, Spilling Memories 1 (2022): collection record

Numbered references support the biography and exhibition entries. Source titles are clickable. Artwork images and object records are supplied by the collector. The exhibition selection is not a complete career CV.

The Ozuwo Enifome Collection

Kelani Abass
Six early paintings | 2006-2007

For specialist gallery assessment,
collection enquiries and private viewing requests.

Ozuwo Enifome
Private collector | Nigeria

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